courts, creating further delays.

The 1950 Act, by contrast, allows for much swifter action. Sarma contends that a recent SC constitutional bench ruling (October 17, 2024, in a case concerning Section 6A of the Citizenship Act) validates this approach, thereby facilitating swifter "pushbacks", occasionally even without antecedent FT proceedings. The SC bench, in upholding Section 6A, explicitly stated that the IEAA "shall be effectively employed for the purpose of identification of illegal immigrants", granting the Centre the power to remove immigrants deemed "detrimental to the interests of India".

At least 330 declared foreigners have reportedly been "pushed back" into Bangladesh. In January 2025, when more than 200 individuals were found languishing for years in Matia detention centre, the country's largest, the SC expressed stern disapproval over the delay and directed the government to expedite the deportation process.

However, executing the court order has not been easy. Bangladesh has shown little enthusiasm for accepting deportees, especially those unable to provide clear proof of their nationality. The 14 people who were "pushed back" in May but then spent days in no-man's land before returning to Assam illustrated the practical limitations of the deportation policy. Without cooperation from Bangladesh, many deportation orders become political farce.

That, indeed, is what Himanta's drive has become. By reviving the decades-old fear of demographic alteration, the Assam CM is reactivating the BJP's Hindu-Muslim binary in a state where religion, language and indigeneity form an unstable triangle. His messaging is aimed squarely at indigenous communities who have historically felt threatened by migration from erstwhile East Bengal and later Bangladesh. Sarma's "uncompromising" stand on security and illegal immigration is designed to consolidate this support base. On June 25, he signalled a renewed push to reclaim land for indigenous communities by intensifying the crackdown on alleged encroachments by illegal immigrants. Soon after taking office, Sarma had launched a series of eviction drives, largely targeting Bangla-speaking Muslims.

Several recent incidents in Assam, where meat was allegedly found near temples following Eid celebrations, have reinforced the narrative the BJP is trying to push. Sarma was quick to frame these acts as "the weaponisation of beef against Hindus", amplifying communal tensions. Another polarising move has been the government's decision to issue arms licences to "original inhabitants" in vulnerable border areas. This has been widely interpreted as an attempt to strengthen perceptions of insecurity and promote community-based self-defence. Sarma has urged citizens to adopt a firm stance. "Modiji alone cannot protect us," he warned, insisting that unless the Assamese people themselves resist infiltration, neither laws nor leaders can preserve their identity.

ANI

SUPPORTING DUE PROCESS AND MINORITY RIGHTS PUTS THE CONGRESS IN A BIND, LEAVING IT VULNERABLE TO CHARGES OF BEING "PRO-FOREIGNER"

Sarma's political intent becomes more apparent when considered alongside Assam's shifting electoral dynamics. The All India United Democratic Front, once a key force representing Muslim interests, has been significantly weakened. This opens up space for the Congress to reclaim Muslim support. At the same time, it gives the BJP an opportunity to label any Congress-Muslim alliance as evidence of the party's alleged "anti-national" leanings. The Congress finds itself in a complicated position. Supporting due process and minority rights leaves it vulnerable to charges of being "pro-foreigner". But remaining silent in the face of what critics see as systematic persecution of a certain group undermines its secular credentials. The recent appointment of Gaurav Gogoi as state Congress president was an attempt to find a leader who could navigate these treacherous political waters.

But Gogoi's own background has given Sarma ample ammunition for attack. The BJP leader has accused Gogoi and his British wife of being Pakistani sympathisers gathering intelligence on Indian soil. Sarma's announcement that he will reveal "evidence" on September 10 appears strategically timed to build anti-Congress sentiment. For Gogoi and the Congress, the stakes are high. Gogoi's appointment suggests the Congress is willing to stake its fortunes on a direct contest with Sarma. But the BJP's narrative, of a Muslim-friendly Congress allegedly compromised by foreign interests, could prove a potent challenge in Assam's volatile electoral arena.

As Assam approaches the election, Sarma's efforts are not only aimed at consolidating the BJP's support base but are also subtly redefining the terms of political engagement in the state, where the boundaries between governance and campaign rhetoric are getting increasingly blurred. ■